



Volume III | Issue II October 2016

PAHAL



CONTENTS

DISHA DAY 2016.....(2)

A WEEKEND ON
SHRAMDHAN(3)

JIGYASA SCIENCE CAMP
.....(4)

SANJAY GANDHI VASAHAT
SURVEY(6)

MEET THE CURRENT
COORDINATORS.....(7)

THE SPARK BEHIND AN
INITIATIVE(8)

Design credits: Swastik Mishra

EDITORIAL

The ideology of Disha for the previous years has been to assist the current education system, by teaching and inspiring young minds. This choice comes from the fact that, being privileged enough to be studying in a premier institute, attempting to alleviate the educational status of some of the less privileged is an effective way for the volunteers to give back to society. This has been the mindset until this past summer. Along this line, the Jigyasa Camp was successfully organised over the summer. In addition to this, however, Disha has extended its domain of social work by taking up initiatives to help in the drought-hit areas of Maharashtra, described in this issue in *The Spark Behind An Initiative* by Kumar Priyadarshi and *A Weekend of Shramdhan* by Shubham Joge. This has been a noteworthy and welcome milestone for Disha as it establishes that it is not a rigid organisation in terms of the causes towards which it works.

Even though, by now, the Abhiyasika volunteers know a lot about the people living in the vastis they go to teach in, it was realised that for a systematic analysis of the progress with the children and for a long-term impact on the society as a whole, a deeper understanding of the children's family backgrounds is required. Prachi Atmasiddha writes in *Sanjay Gandhi Vasahat Survey* about how students went to each house in the vasti surveying using questionnaires that the team had thoughtfully prepared.

This issue, called "New Beginnings", talks about the new initiatives taken up by Disha, keeping in mind the bigger cause and working towards it in a sustainable manner. While it still targets improvement in education because that is what volunteers are reasonably well-equipped to target, we commend Disha's involvement in more causes, as well as the execution of new strategies to improve previously established agendas. With the new semester under way, we are pleased to see that there has been a huge addition of highly enthusiastic and supportive volunteers to the Disha family from the new batch of students this year. With a fresh mindset and hopes for the future, we sign off as editors of Pahal, handing it over to Abhijeet Pendse.

Danish Kaur and Rahul Iyer



Disha Day is an occasion for all of us in Disha to look back on the events of the past year while simultaneously planning for those in the upcoming year. This year Disha Day was held on 17th April 2016 in C-201 (the multipurpose hall in the guest house). The programme saw the attendance of many professors from IISER Pune, including Dr. Nagaraj Balasubramanian, Dr. Sudha Rajamani and Prof. Sunil Mukhi, as well as few dignitaries from outside IISER.

The program commenced with a melodious Veena recital by Akshay Nair and Chaitra Agrahar. This was followed by a group singing perfor-

mance by Rasika Daware, Shubha Bhat and Praful Rahate. The stirring music really set the tone for the program. This was followed by a presentation which introduced to the audience all the activities that Disha has conducted in the past year. After the presentation, volunteers from each programme came forward to share their experiences with Disha. Some students from other colleges in Pune who had participated in Spread the Smile also shared their experiences with the audience. Their stories were funny, inspirational and heart rending.

Prof. Sunil Mukhi appreciated the ef-

forts of our volunteers and regaled us with stories of his time in TIFR, where he and his friends taught underprivileged children. Dr. Sudha Rajamani also commended our dedication and pledged to support Disha in every way possible. The editors of Pahal- Danish, Reema and Rahul, then came forward to release its latest issue.

The program concluded with fund-raising dinner which was prepared by a women's self-help group from Sanjay Gandhi Vasahat, Pashan. The sumptuous dinner was a great end to an altogether satisfying day.



A WEEKEND ON SHRAMDHAN

Shubham Joge

For the past few years, several places in Maharashtra have been facing acute drought. Consequently, an alarming number of farmers have committed suicide. In almost all cases, the primary reason for their suicides was being in a state of heavy debt. This is saddening considering the integral role farmers play in our lives, slogging to provide food for us, despite the circumstances. As the socially conscious and responsible youth of society, it is our duty to provide any possible assistance to them in such dire conditions.

With this sentiment, around 76 PhD students from IISER, NCL, SPPU came together and volunteered for field work for NAAM foundation. Founded by esteemed actors Nana Patekar and Makarand Anaspure, NAAM foundation works towards building a sustainable and progressive society by facilitating development in rural areas by working on different issues like infrastructure, education, employment, food etc. Field work involved conducting a survey to find out needy and destitute farmers.



We conducted this survey on the 5th and 6th of March in 60 villages of Ashti Tehsil in Beed district which contains 177 villages. Between us, we went to each household with questionnaires, and based on their answers our responsibility was to determine the degree of their crisis. Based on this information, the foundation would provide financial aid to these farmers, prioritizing those in extreme crisis first. The results of the survey shed light to the wretched situation of these villages, as 80-90% of the households were declared to be in urgent need, while quite a few

were declared to be in very urgent need.

This was an unforgettable experience for all of us, as we witnessed such dismal conditions up close. However, we felt satisfied for being part of a relief-providing program.



JIGYASA SCIENCE CAMP

Mitali Thatte and Saurabh Kadam

Disha and IISER Pune conducted the Jigyasa Science Camp for underprivileged students from 21st – 24th July. These students came from Dantewada district of Chhattisgarh. Bachpan Banao, a voluntary organisation working in the education sector in Chhattisgarh, was responsible for providing an opportunity to these students to attend this Science camp. The students greatly enjoyed the four days of science activities, demonstrations and games conducted by Disha volunteers.

The train bringing these students from Dantewada to Pune pulled in at Pune junction on the 20th of July. It was immediately clear from the expression on their faces that the kids were slightly bewildered to find themselves in so large a city. Their nervousness levels shot right up on finding themselves in a big unfamiliar hostel and being given their own keys to their rooms. Their first meal in IISER was marked by absolute silence. It was only during the evening when the volunteers conducted a few ice-breaking games that they opened up and began to feel comfortable in IISER.

The next day was officially the first

day of the Jigyasa Science Camp. It started with a documentary film about the wonders of nature followed by a welcome note by Apurva Barve. This was followed by the much anticipated tour of the IISER campus. The students visited the undergraduate physics lab, the Bubble Chamber, the Fly Lab, the Greenhouse and the Library among other places. The kids appeared delighted to look through the windows of the labs in Mendeleev, H-cross and G I. But the highlight of the day was the balloon car racing session conducted on the ground floor of the dining block for which the kids had to make their own cars using water bottles, balloons, straws etc.

Day 2 began with a lecture about general health and hygiene followed by a highly popular session demonstrating the properties of liquid nitrogen. In the afternoon there was a visit to Quest, a science centre in Aundh, and a hands-on activity session. The kids had fun trying out different science experiments themselves.

After spending two days in the IISER campus, the third day was the day of the visit to the Pimpri-Chinchwad

Science Park and probably the best day of their stay in Pune. The kids enjoyed the 3-D Science and Taramandal shows enormously and were enthusiastically asking about and trying out different science games and activities displayed in the museum. It was the volunteers who had the tougher job of explaining and translating everything in Hindi (the only language understood by everyone in the group).

The final day began with a 'Fun with Maths' session by Dr. Anisa Chorwadwala. Post lunch, there was a screening of the movie 'Nil Battay Sannata'. In the evening there was a short Physics demonstration session followed by an art and craft and sports hour. It had dawned upon everyone that the science camp was almost at an end and emotions were running high especially among the kids.

The camp was a great success which exposed the underprivileged students to the world of science and the volunteers to the educational reality of rural India.





My personal experience:

The four days of Jigyasa camp were undoubtedly the best ones of my entire summer. I had worked for the Abhyasikas and Spread the Smile for two years; so I was relatively confident of what to expect but I was amazed by the amount of work that went into organizing everything (not that I did much of it, Saurabh almost single-handedly planned and organized the entire thing but because I volunteered for

the entire duration of the camp, I got to know exactly how much planning it takes to pull something like this off). The days would be long and tiring but the energy and the enthusiasm of the kids and other volunteers was worth it. The kids were shy at first but they eventually warmed up to us and by the time the camp ended they adored all the 'bhaiyas' and 'didis' of Disha. Jigyasa was all about bringing the joy of science into the lives of these

kids for whom the word science is probably just the first half of a 'science textbook'. We certainly tried our best to do that but in the process we learned a lot as well. We learned about their lives, views and perspectives. All in all, it was a fun and satisfying experience.

Mitali Thatte



SANJAY GANDHI VASAHAT SURVEY

Prachi Atmasiddha

Disha has developed into an organization which inspires people to work for a social cause and spreads awareness of the situation of other people eking out a living on limited resources. We have been trying to work in the area of education and enlightening young minds through various programmes. Even though we try to bring children to IISER to broaden their view of this world in programmes like Science Nurture Programme and Mindspark, I personally believe that the heart of Disha lies in Abhyasika Programme, where we go to the vastis (slums), which are not far away from our campus, and conduct classes there. It shows a different kind of social awareness to work at the grassroot level, to try interacting with the denizens there, build a connection with them and to gradually bring change. We seek a more gradual and permanent change, which may not be evident in the short term.

We have been conducting classes in two vastis near IISER: Laman Vasti and Sanjay Gandhi Vasahat for 5 years. We have built a nice healthy connection with the residents there, but somehow we never conducted any properly organized meticulous survey about the people living there. We knew that their conditions are not conducive to studies but still we had not put our efforts to get to know them properly, so we decided to do so this year.

The motivation to conduct this survey is mainly to know whether their home environment is favourable for the children to study, to understand the reasons behind drop-outs from school at young ages or loss of interest in studies amongst kids

and quantify the same, and we prepared a questionnaire with this in mind. We are noting down the total income of the family and the total approximate expense for the studies and healthcare. We are also asking them whether the parents have any plans for their children or whether the children have any ambitions. This is to see how motivated the entire family is about their higher education. We are also asking some miscellaneous questions like their native village, how long have they been living here in the vasti, etc. We also reserved the question: "Why do you think education is necessary?", for the sake of curiosity and to get a notion of their perception about the importance of education.

In phase one, we plan to cover every house in Sanjay Gandhi Vasahat. We started this survey in April 2016. A lot of IISER students, who were not a part of our regular Disha activities, also helped us in this survey. In the first week of the survey, we got an idea about the residents' response to the questions and decided to make some changes in the questionnaire accordingly.

Overall the responses we got to our questions were very telling. For example, usually only the men in the family would know the economic status of the family and the women would be clueless, but if the women were also working, then there was a higher probability that they would know how much their income per month was. If it was a girl asking them questions then mostly the woman of the house would answer those, but if a guy is asking questions, then men will come to the door to answer them: this was

the general trend. This would affect the kind of information we obtained about that family.

The entire Sanjay Gandhi Vasahat is predominantly inhabited by migrants from far away villages in Maharashtra and Telangana along with a small set of population hailing from Bihar and Delhi. They shifted in Pune mostly during the drought which casted a pall over Maharashtra in 1970-1973. Most of the families have been staying in Vasti for 40-50 years and occasionally visit their native place. They are now dwellers of Pune with very weak links with their actual native place. However, people from Telangana do teach their kids about their native regions while they stay here to earn for the family and hope to ultimately return, if possible, to their own villages in the future.

Most of the children in the community go to school, but there are a few children who left school well before completing high-school for some genuine reasons as well as because of lack of interest in their studies. We wish to investigate further in this. Most of the children's parents had studied till at least 5th standard and seemed interested in their kids' further education. All the parents' wish was to let their kids get higher and better education than they themselves received.

Most of the families have minor health problems but were not suffering from any chronic diseases, and most of them seemed aware of the vaccination programmes. They get primary health care from a near-by government clinic or some doctors in Pashan.

We have not yet analyzed the entire data diligently, but we plan to do

that as soon as possible and start surveying Laman Vasti which we think is a more challenging task.

It was a different experience from teaching the kids in our programmes. I realized that here in our cozy, comfortable lives we struggle for enjoyment, comfort and happiness. We have great ambitions for our studies because our stomach is full with all the junk we intake every-

day not thinking about the money we spend. I did not see much enthusiasm on the faces of some of the parents', when I asked them whether they want their children to pursue higher education. Deep in their minds, they are mostly concerned about their living standards and very basic needs. Education is a luxury for some of them, not a basic need. I think all these things have to be kept in mind while entering into their locali-

ty with a budding idea of bringing a change. In spite of all the problems they are facing I could see a smile on their faces which showed how they were embracing their lives and accepting their challenges. I did not see many of them in a forlorn state. That was the source of hope I saw. They want change. I think as volunteers, we should find and enhance this hope in every child.

MEET THE CURRENT COORDINATORS

CORE TEAM

General Coordinators



Saurabh Kadam



Mukta Joshi



Mitali Thatte
(Resource team and Spread
the Smile)



Reema Jamal
(Abhyasikas)



Aboli Ektare
(Mindspark Coordinator)

Laman Vasti Abhyasika Coordinators



Sriram Raghunath



Aarti Kejriwal

Someshwarwadi Abhyasika Coordinators



Lokesh Tayade



Rishabh Bagawade

Science Nurture Program Coordinators



Aniket Khairnar



Devesh Verma

THE SPARK BEHIND THE INITIATIVE

Kumar Priyadarshi

Talking to friends is a luxury if you were lucky to find the right ones. In one of my many facebook conversations on socio-economic and political status of this country on global map and our contribution in same, a friend of mine who founded EK PAHAL at IISER-K, a similar organization as DISHA as we have here at IISER-P, working for the upliftment of marginalized sectors of society, said this to me:

“The FB activism is a false satisfaction and merely an escapist attitude towards the problems that we are dealing with. Come out of it and try doing something on the ground (small though this may be) rather posting intellectual statuses.”

This was the time when the JNU issue was at its peak, and I for one thought there was a big change coming. I read and watched almost everything available on the issue which eventually led me to an interview by Nana Patekar saying something about drought hitting Marathwada region in Maharashtra. The issue got controversial with IPL season approaching and the government finally woke up from their state of inactivity. Once I had read a great deal about this, I realized how serious the issue was and how we, inspite of being hardly a few hundred kilometers from this place, were enjoying our life as if everything was normal. Even Maharashtrian people were hardly aware of the dire situa-

tion of these drought hit areas.

The Hindu wrote “Maharashtra is witnessing one of the worst drought situations in history. 27000 out of 43000 villages (62%) have been declared hit (in September 2015 only). 54 out of 75 dams have been declared dry. The state is left with 380 cubic metres of water for use making life worse than hell. Around 2600 suicides happened between Jan to Oct 2015. This year also around 57 farmers have committed suicide before March 1st.”

Despite knowing that drought was declared way back in September 2015 and the situation from last 4 years have been quite alarming, not much government aid was given to these areas. Although I kept reading more about the reasons of such drastic situations in one of the more developed states of India, this was the time to walk out of our study room and do something on the ground.

I would not say I got the support as much as I expected but still enough to start the initiative. Prasanth, Prachi, Abhijeet were mostly part of all the meetings and decisions. We decided to contribute the money to a recently established foundation called NAAM, whose authenticity was approved by the natives of those villagers themselves. When we dug in, we came across various initiatives NAAM had planned. Distributing sewing machines to wom-

en, schools for poor kids, agriculture awareness to farmers, cleaning rivers to store rainwater, water harvesting and so on.

Thanks to IISERites, we collected ₹1,05,480 and donated that to NAAM foundation. We are planning to visit these areas and see the situation so that we being science students can provide our inputs to help them recover from their situation.

As Nana says: “If these people can kill themselves, how much time do you think it will take for them to start killing us?”

So, it is time for us to see what challenges our society faces and what kind of betterment we can bring to the same. If each one of us decide to help one person who needs our help, I think very soon our society would be a much better place to live. We should always think of

“Kuch aisi hamari duniyadaari ho jahan har phool mein kaante ki bhi hisse daari ho”

After the collection of funds, I replied to my friend the realization that I had: *“Baat naa toh samay ki hai, naa paise ki, baat naa toh koshish ki hai naa sahyog ki, baat bas ye hai ki aap apne alawa aur kisi ke baare mein sochte hain ya nahi.”*

Freshers speak!

“If you want to talk all about that new concept you learnt, this is the place to do it. You can open the kids’ eyes to a new, exciting view of science. Or you can explain something as simple as Newton’s Laws, and hear them screaming and cheering when that Water Rocket your team made reaches the third floor and they learn the third law!” - Aagam Shah on Science Nurture Program

“I believe that getting an opportunity to do something is even more valuable than succeeding in it. The thought of being able to provide children with an opportunity to study and realize its importance is what motivates me to take step to help.” - Aasim Saifee on Abhyasikas

Reach out to Disha:

Disha blog: www.iiserpunedisha.wordpress.com

Disha Facebook page: www.facebook.com/Disha-IISER-Pune-570481279647490

Disha e-mail ID: disha@sac.iiserpune.ac.in